A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Jude 3–4

The Battle Cry: Contend Earnestly for the Faith

Small Group Bible Study Series · Jude

Source: The Gospel Vault

Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NASB · Jude 3–4

3 *Beloved, while I was making every effort to write you about our common salvation, I felt the necessity to write to you appealing that you contend earnestly for the faith which was once for all handed down to the saints.*

4 *For certain persons have crept in unnoticed, those who were long beforehand marked out for this condemnation, ungodly persons who turn the grace of our God into licentiousness and deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *"Beloved, while I was making every effort to write you about our common salvation, I felt the necessity to write to you appealing that you contend earnestly for the faith which was once for all handed down to the saints."*

Jude had one letter in his heart and another on his desk. He wanted to write about the salvation every believer shares. Instead, something forced his hand: people were turning God's grace into a license to do as they pleased, and the faith itself was being altered.

Notice that his call to fight comes out of love, not out of a love of argument. You contend for what you treasure. The faith was handed down to you — you did not invent it, and you are not free to improve it. Your task is to receive it, believe it, and hand it on whole.

That is a calming thought as much as a challenging one. You are not the author of the gospel. You are its steward, and the One who gave it is the One who keeps you.

Reflect

1. What is the "common salvation" you most want to protect in your own church or family?
2. Where have you been tempted to soften or adjust the gospel so that it feels easier to hand on?
3. What would it look like for you to contend for the faith with love instead of with heat?

The faith was handed down once. Our job is to hand it on whole.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Jude set aside the letter he wanted to write — about our common salvation — to urge believers to contend earnestly for the faith once for all handed down, because men had slipped in who turned God's grace into license and denied the Lord.

Introduction — The Letter Jude Did Not Write

One of the most revealing things about a person is what he almost said. Jude tells us he was "making every effort" to write a different letter. The Greek word, *spoudē*, means eagerness, even longing. He had that letter in his heart and the pen in his hand. It was to be about "our common salvation" — the shared life of grace that ties every believer to every other believer.

He did not write it. "I felt the necessity," he says, and the word *anankē* means compulsion from outside himself. Paul uses the same word when he says "woe is me if I do not preach the gospel" (1 Corinthians 9:16). Jude was not choosing between a pleasant subject and an unpleasant one. A pastoral emergency made the first letter impossible to write in good conscience. He is like a doctor who stopped by for a routine visit and found a patient in crisis.

Every pastor and teacher knows the pull toward the warm sermon instead of the hard one. Jude shows how to answer it. He does not abandon the warm letter. He writes the urgent one first, and the common salvation he wanted to celebrate is the reason the urgent one exists.

I. The Change of Plan – v. 3a

A. Our common salvation

"Common" here does not mean ordinary. It means shared — held in common by every believer, whatever his background, education, or standing. It is the one possession no circumstance can create or take away, and it is why this letter is addressed to a whole community and not to a few experts.

The warmth in this phrase matters. Jude's battle cry is not a departure from his love for the common salvation. It is the expression of it. You cannot love something and be indifferent when it is attacked.

B. The necessity

What forced the change is named in verse 4. Something was happening inside the church that could not wait. Jude's response is not to panic and not to ignore it. He turns his readers from the warm subject to the urgent one — and he does it as a pastor who is still writing to people he calls "beloved."

II. The Battle Cry – v. 3b

A. Contend earnestly

"Contend earnestly" is one Greek word, *epagōnizesthai*, found only here in the New Testament. Its root is *agōn*, the word for an athletic contest — a race or a wrestling match that demands everything on the day of the event. The prefix adds intensity. To *epagōnizomai* for something is to agonize for it, to pour yourself out for it as if the outcome depended on you.

That is not the language of casual theological preference. Jude is not asking his readers to hold their views with mild conviction and mention them politely if asked. He is saying: fight for this. But look at what the fight is for. You do not fight the faith; you fight *for* it. The contest is not against people — their judgment belongs to God, as the next section will show — but for the preservation and handing on of the apostolic deposit. A church that fights against people is consumed by conflict. A church that fights for the gospel is defined by its love of the gospel.

Paul uses the same family of words elsewhere. He tells the Philippians to be "striving together for the faith of the gospel" (Philippians 1:27) and tells Timothy to "fight the good fight of the faith" (1 Timothy 6:12). In each case the faith is something worth fighting for, and the fight is shared: not a solitary crusade, but a community standing shoulder to shoulder. Jude's "contend" is a plural command to a whole church.

B. The faith once for all handed down

The object of the contending is "the faith which was once for all handed down to the saints." *Hapax* means once for all, once only, never to be repeated. *Paradotheisē* is an aorist passive of *paradidōmi*: to hand over, to deliver, to entrust. The aorist points to a completed historical act. Someone handed this faith to the saints at a definite time, and that handing-down is finished. The deposit is closed.

This matters enormously. "The faith" here is the apostolic message — what the apostles taught about Jesus Christ and the gospel. It is a fixed content. We are receivers, not originators. The church's relationship to the faith is that of trustee, not artist. We may explain the gospel in new words, illustrate it with new pictures, and apply it to new situations; that is faithful handing-on. What "once for all" forbids is altering the content: adding conditions to the promise, subtracting its comfort, or redirecting its focus from Christ to ourselves.

Paul says the same to Timothy: "Retain the standard of sound words which you have heard from me… Guard, through the Holy Spirit who dwells in us, the treasure which has been entrusted to you" (2 Timothy 1:13–14). And he tells Timothy to entrust what he has heard to faithful men who will teach others also (2 Timothy 2:2). The pattern is receive, guard, hand on. Galatians 1:8–9 shows how serious it is: if anyone, even an angel, preaches another gospel, "let him be accursed." The faith is not up for revision.

A will that has been probated is a closed document. You cannot add heirs after the testator has died, and you cannot change the terms. The lawyer's job is not to improve it but to preserve it and administer it faithfully. The church's job with the apostolic faith is the same.

III. The Infiltrators – v. 4

A. They crept in unnoticed

Jude now names the crisis: “certain persons have crept in unnoticed.” *Pareisedysan* is a compound verb picturing someone slipping in alongside, through a side door, without detection. This is not an army on the horizon. It is infiltration. The enemy is already inside, at the table, using the right words.

That is one of Jude’s most uncomfortable insights. The most dangerous threats to the gospel rarely announce themselves. By the time the danger is visible, some of the damage has already been done. The community’s greatest strengths — its hospitality and openness — become the door. The answer is not to give up welcome but to pair it with wisdom: the table is for everyone, and discernment sits at the table too.

The New Testament remembers the same thing happening before. Paul speaks of “false brethren secretly brought in, who had sneaked in to spy out our liberty which we have in Christ Jesus, in order to bring us into bondage” (Galatians 2:4). The verb is from the same family as Jude’s *pareisedysan*. The aim was not simply to teach something different, but to take away liberty. Infiltration works because it looks like fellowship. It is the oldest strategy in the book, and the church has met it in every age.

B. Marked out long beforehand

The phrase “long beforehand marked out for this condemnation” translates *progegrammenoi*, “written about beforehand.” Some Reformed interpreters take this as eternal reprobation — these men were decreed from eternity to this end. The context points elsewhere. Jude immediately proves his point from the Old Testament (vv. 5–11): the judgment on this pattern of behavior was written about long ago, in the stories of the wilderness generation, the fallen angels, Sodom, Cain, Balaam, and Korah. The “long beforehand” is the record of Scripture, not a secret decree. Jude does not tell us whether these men were ever believers, and nothing in his argument depends on deciding. He tells us what they do and where it leads.

C. Two charges: license and denial

Jude gives two descriptions. First, they “turn the grace of our God into licentiousness.” *Aselgeia* is unrestrained, shameless self-indulgence. These men took the most freeing truth in the universe and used it as permission for the very thing grace was meant to free people from. Grace rightly understood is not the removal of the fence at the cliff edge; it is the gift of eyes to see the cliff and the strength to walk away from it (Titus 2:11–12).

Paul meets this error head on. “Are we to continue in sin so that grace may increase? May it never be!” (Romans 6:1–2). “Shall we sin because we are not under law but under grace? May it never be!” (Romans 6:15). Paul does not answer the objection by shrinking grace. He answers it by showing what grace does: it breaks the old master’s hold, and it gives us a new Master. Jude is making the same argument from the other side. Those who turn grace into license have not understood what grace is. And notice that even Paul’s critics accused him of teaching this (Romans 3:8). If your gospel can’t be mistaken for license, it is not the gospel Paul preached.

Second, they “deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ.” Whether the denial is spoken or lived, it is the logical partner of the first. If grace is license, there is no Lord to whom the believer answers. Together the two errors empty the faith of its Master.

This is the point at which Free Grace is most often misunderstood — and Jude helps. Critics such as John MacArthur argue that a gospel which makes eternal life a free gift without regard to obedience is the very license Jude condemns.[1] Free Grace replies that Jude condemns using grace *as an excuse for sin*, not the free offer of eternal life by faith alone, and that the answer to license is not to add works to the condition of salvation but to teach what grace itself teaches.[2] Jude’s own remedy confirms this: he will not call believers to qualify for the keeping of verse 1 but to build up, pray, and keep themselves in God’s love (vv. 20–21).

One pastoral caution. Jude’s description should not produce a church that sees an infiltrator behind every hard question. The marks he gives are specific: turning grace into license and denying the Lord. Those are not the marks of sincere doubt or honest struggle. Discernment, not suspicion, is the response he asks for.

Conclusion

The battle cry of verse 3 is not the cry of a man who loves a fight. It is the cry of a man who loves the common salvation and could not write about it in peace because it was being taken from the people he loved. The urgency to contend comes from love, not from love of argument.

The faith was handed down once. It is not ours to modify, soften, or improve. Our task is to receive it, believe it, and — when necessary, and it is often necessary — to fight for it. Not with bitterness or contempt, but with the full effort the word *epagōnizesthai* demands. What is at stake is not our theological reputation. It is the common salvation, the one thing every person in every room needs.

Lord, give us love for the faith, and wisdom to guard it.

Sources and Notes

1. On Lordship Salvation: John F. MacArthur, *The Gospel According to Jesus* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1988; rev. 2008) and *The Gospel According to the Apostles* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2000). Free Grace reply: Zane C. Hodges, *Absolutely Free! A Biblical Reply to Lordship Salvation* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan, 1989); Charles C. Ryrie, *So Great Salvation* (Wheaton: Victor Books, 1989).

2. Free Grace on grace and godly living: Charles C. Bing, *Simply by Grace* (Grand Rapids: Kregel, 2009); Robert N. Wilkin, *Confident in Christ* (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 1999); Robert N. Wilkin, ed., *The Grace New Testament Commentary* (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 2010), on Jude.

3. Word studies: Blue Letter Bible lexicon entries G4710 (*spoudē*), G318 (*anankē*), G1864 (*epagōnizomai*), G530 (*hapax*), G3860 (*paradidōmi*), G3921 (*pareisdyō*), G4270 (*prographō*), G766 (*aselgeia*), G720 (*arneomai*), G1203 (*despotēs*); BDAG, 3rd ed.

4. Reformed reading of “marked out”: see the discussion in Thomas R. Schreiner, *1, 2 Peter, Jude*, New American Commentary (Nashville: Broadman & Holman, 2003); Thomas L. Constable, *Expository Notes on Jude*, planobiblechapel.org/tcon/notes/.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.3	**σπουδήν** earnestness, eagerness	G4710 spoudēn N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: haste, diligence, earnestness. Significance: Jude's original intent was strong and warm — "making every effort" to write about the common salvation.
v.3	**κοινῆς** common, shared	G2839 koinēs Adj.-Gen. Sg. Fem.	STR: common, shared by all. Significance: not "ordinary," but held in common by every believer — the salvation that binds the whole community.
v.3	**σωτηρίας** salvation	G4991 sōtērias N-Gen. Sg. Fem.	STR: deliverance, salvation. Significance: here the shared salvation of all believers, the thing Jude wanted to celebrate and now must defend.
v.3	**ἀνάγκην** necessity, compulsion	G318 anankēn N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: necessity. Significance: pressure from outside himself. Compare 1 Cor. 9:16. The crisis changed the letter.
v.3	**ἐπαγωνίζεσθαι** to contend earnestly	G1864 epagōnizesthai Pres. Mid. Inf.	Only here in the NT. Root *agōn*, an athletic contest; the prefix intensifies. Significance: full-effort struggle *for* the faith — not against people.
v.3	**ἅπαξ** once for all	G530 hapax Adv.	STR: once, one time. Significance: once-for-all, never repeated. Cf. Heb. 9:26–28. The deposit of the faith is complete.
v.3	**παραδοθείσῃ** handed down	G3860 paradotheisē Aor. Pass. Ptc. Dat. Sg. Fem.	STR: to hand over, deliver. Significance: aorist = a completed historical act by someone else. We receive the faith; we do not create it.
v.4	**παρεισέδυσαν** crept in unnoticed	G3921 pareisedysan Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Pl.	STR: to slip in stealthily. Significance: infiltration through a side door, not open assault. The danger is internal and quiet.
v.4	**προγεγραμμένοι** marked out beforehand	G4270 progegrammenoi Perf. Pass. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to write beforehand. Significance: "written about long ago" — the Scripture record (vv. 5–11) — not a secret eternal decree.
v.4	**κρίμα** condemnation, judgment	G2917 krima N-Acc. Sg. Neut.	STR: a judicial verdict. Significance: the sentence that the pattern of behavior in vv. 5–16 has always earned.
v.4	**ἀσέλγειαν** licentiousness	G766 aselgeian N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: unbridled lust, excess. Significance: grace turned into license — the classic antinomian error.
v.4	**ἀρνούμενοι** denying	G720 arnoumenoi Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Pl.	STR: to deny, refuse. Significance: present tense — a characteristic, ongoing posture toward "our only Master and Lord."

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
		Masc.	
v.4	**δεσπότην** Master	G1203 despotēn N-Acc. Sg. Masc.	STR: absolute ruler, owner. Significance: the counterpart of Jude's own title *doulos* (v. 1). He serves the Master these men deny.

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
Why did Jude change the letter he was writing?	He had been eager to write about the common salvation, but he felt compelled to write instead, urging believers to contend for the faith, because false teachers had crept in.
What does "common salvation" mean?	The salvation shared by every believer, whatever his background — the one possession no circumstance can create or remove.
What does "contend earnestly" (*epagōnizesthai*) teach about how believers should defend the faith?	It pictures full-effort struggle *for* something treasured, not against people. The fight is for preserving and handing on the apostolic deposit.
What does "once for all handed down" tell us about "the faith"?	It is a fixed content received from the apostles, finished and complete. We are trustees, not inventors.
What does "marked out long beforehand" most likely mean?	That the judgment on this pattern of behavior was written about long ago in Scripture (vv. 5–11), not a secret decree. Jude does not say whether these men were ever believers.
What are the two charges against the intruders in v. 4?	They turn the grace of God into licentiousness, and they deny our only Master and Lord, Jesus Christ.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Jude put aside a warm letter to write an urgent one. When have you had to choose between comfort and what a situation demanded?

> *Leader note: See Commentary Introduction and I.*

2. What does it change to think of yourself as a "trustee" of the faith rather than an inventor of it?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.B — "once for all handed down."*

3. How do you tell the difference between contending *for* the faith and fighting *against* people?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.A — epagōnizesthai and its object.*

4. Why are infiltrators more dangerous than open opponents? How can a welcoming church still stay discerning?

> *Leader note: See Commentary III.A.*

5. Critics say a gospel of free grace invites license. How does Jude's remedy in vv. 20–21 answer that, without adding works to the condition of salvation?

> *Leader note: See Commentary III.C — MacArthur and the Free Grace reply; Titus 2:11–12.*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
v. 3a	The change of plan	Love for the common salvation first wanted to celebrate it, and then had to defend it.
v. 3b	The battle cry	Contend earnestly for the faith once for all handed down — a fixed content received from the apostles.
v. 4a	The infiltration	The danger came from inside and arrived quietly, as the gospel's defenders slept.
v. 4b	The two charges	Grace turned into license; the only Master and Lord denied.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Love What You Defend

Jude 3a

Drawn from Commentary Introduction and I. Key terms: spoudēn (eagerness), koinēs (common).

Jude fights because he loves. The common salvation was what he wanted to write about, and its endangerment is what made him pick up the pen. If we contend for the faith without loving it, the contending turns into mere argument.

Reflection: When you stand up for the gospel, do the people with you sense that you love it, or that you love being right?

Practical Step: Before your next doctrinal conversation, tell the person one thing about the gospel you are glad of.

Application 2 — Receive It and Hand It On Whole

Jude 3b

Drawn from Commentary II.B. Key terms: hapax (once for all), paradotheisē (handed down).

We are trustees. The apostolic faith does not need our improvements, only our faithful handing-on. New words, new pictures, and new applications are welcome; changing the content is not.

Reflection: Where have you been tempted to soften or adjust the gospel to make it easier to hand on?

Practical Step: Write the gospel in three sentences, using only what the apostles taught. Compare it with how you actually explain it to others.

Application 3 — Recognize Quiet Infiltration

Jude 4

Drawn from Commentary III.A–B. Key term: pareisedysan (crept in unnoticed).

Dangerous teaching seldom arrives announced. It arrives at the table, using the right language. The remedy is not suspicion, but steady familiarity with the apostolic faith — so that a departure from it is noticed early.

Reflection: Which voices — books, podcasts, teachers — are shaping you most? Have you tested them against the apostolic message?

Practical Step: Read the one-page summary of the gospel in 1 Corinthians 15:1–4 each day this week and compare it with what you are hearing.

Application 4 — Answer License with Grace, Not with Works

Jude 4; Titus 2:11–12

Drawn from Commentary III.C. FGR: Hodges, Absolutely Free!; RTR: MacArthur, The Gospel According to Jesus.

Grace can be abused, and Jude says so plainly. But the cure for license is not to turn grace into a wage. Grace itself teaches us to deny ungodliness. A church that keeps both — grace as free gift, and grace as teacher — honors Jude's whole argument.

Reflection: Where are you tempted to use grace as an excuse? Where are you tempted to add rules to protect it?

Practical Step: Read Titus 2:11–14 slowly. Write down what grace is said to do in our lives, and pray it back as a request.

End of Study · Jude 3–4